

A Manual of Acupuncture: Systemic Theory and Clinical Application

Executive Summary

The study of acupuncture is predicated on a sophisticated network of channels and collaterals (*jingluo*) that integrate the human body into a functional whole. Historically rooted in over two millennia of observation and clinical testing, this tradition provides a comprehensive framework for understanding health, diagnosing pathology, and implementing treatment. The core of the practice involves the stimulation of specific points along these channels to regulate the flow of *qi* and blood. Critical takeaways from the source context include:

- **The Channel Network:** A multi-layered system ranging from superficial cutaneous regions to deep internal pathways that penetrate the *zangfu* (organs).
- **Systemic Integration:** Channels serve four primary functions: transporting *qi* and blood, protecting the body from exogenous pathogens, reflecting internal dysfunction, and transmitting therapeutic stimulation.
- **Point Classification:** Acupuncture points are categorized by their specific energetic functions, such as the Five *Shu* points (representing the flow of *qi* like water), *Yuan* -source points (where original *qi* surfaces), and Back- *shu* / *Front* -mu points (where organ *qi* gathers).
- **Clinical Methodology:** Effective treatment relies on a combination of local and distal point selection, guided by proportional "Cun" measurements and a rigorous adherence to safety protocols to avoid injury to major organs and vessels.

The System of Channels and Collaterals (Jingluo)

The *jingluo* system is the traditional Chinese equivalent of Western anatomy, describing the pathways through which *qi* and blood circulate.

Definitions and Hierarchy

- **Jing (Channels):** The "trunk" or main branches of the network. They run longitudinally and relatively deep, connecting with the internal *zangfu* .
 - **Luo (Collaterals):** The "net" or finer branches. These are more superficial and interconnect the *jing* with connective tissues and cutaneous regions.
- The Hierarchy of Channels (Superficial to Deep):**
1. Cutaneous regions
 2. Minute collaterals
 3. Sinew channels
 4. *Luo* -connecting channels
 5. Primary channels
 6. Divergent channels
 7. Extraordinary channels
 8. Deep pathways of the primary and divergent channels

Primary Functions

1. **Transport:** Moving *qi* and blood to nourish all tissues and sense organs.
2. **Protection:** Acting as a series of barriers to prevent the penetration of exogenous pathogenic factors (wind, cold, damp, heat, etc.).
3. **Response to Dysfunction:** Channels reflect internal disharmony through tenderness, discoloration, or pain.
4. **Transmission:** Conveying the effects of acupuncture needles or moxibustion from the point of stimulation to the diseased area.

The Twelve Primary Channels

There are twelve primary channels running vertically and symmetrically, each corresponding to an internal organ (*zang* or *fu*).

Classification and Pairing

The channels are classified as *Yin* (belonging to *zang* organs) or *Yang* (belonging to *fu* organs).| Circuit | Yin Channel (Hand) | Yang Channel (Hand) | Yang Channel (Foot) | Yin Channel (Foot) || ----- | ----- | ----- | ----- || **First** | Lung | Large Intestine | Stomach | Spleen || **Second** | Heart | Small Intestine | Bladder | Kidney || **Third** | Pericardium | Sanjiao | Gall Bladder | Liver |

Interior-Exterior Relationships

Each *Yang* channel is paired with a *Yin* channel on the same limb, reflecting a physiological and anatomical link between their respective organs. For example, the Lung (*Hand Taiyin*) is interiorly-exteriorly related to the Large Intestine (*Hand Yangming*).

The Eight Extraordinary Vessels

These vessels act as "reservoirs," absorbing excess *qi* and blood from the primary channels. Unlike the primary channels, only the **Conception Vessel (Ren)** and the **Governing Vessel (Du)** have their own specific points.

- **Governing Vessel (Du):** The "Sea of the Yang Channels"; links all *yang* channels at the back.
- **Conception Vessel (Ren):** The "Sea of the Yin Channels"; links all *yin* channels at the front.
- **Penetrating Vessel (Chong):** Known as the "Sea of Blood"; originates in the pelvic cavity and links the Stomach and Kidney channels.
- **Girdling Vessel (Dai):** Encircles the waist like a belt, binding the vertical paths of the primary channels.
- **Motility and Linking Vessels:** Pairs of *Yin* and *Yang* vessels that dominate activity/quietness and the exterior/interior of the body.

Point Categories and Energetic Quality

The Five Shu Points

Located at or distal to the elbows and knees, these points represent the dynamic change of *qi* as it flows toward the trunk. | Point Type | Analogy | Primary Clinical Indication || ----- | ----- | ----- || **Jing-Well** | Qi emanates | Clearing heat, restoring consciousness, fullness below the heart. || **Ying-Spring** | Qi glides | Clearing heat in the body, changes in complexion. || **Shu-Stream** | Qi pours | Heaviness of the body, joint pain, disorders of the *zang*. || **Jing-River** | Qi flows | Cough, dyspnoea, chills, fever, changes in voice. || **He-Sea** | Qi enters | Counterflow *qi*, diarrhoea, disorders of the Stomach/intestines. |

Other Significant Categories

- **Xi-Cleft Points:** Sites where *qi* and blood gather and plunge deeply; used for acute conditions and pain.
- **Yuan-Source Points:** Locations where the "Original Qi" surfaces; vital for tonifying the *zang* organs.
- **Luo-Connecting Points:** Points where the collaterals diverge to connect with the interiorly-exteriorly related channel.
- **Back-shu and Front-mu Points:** Diagnostic and therapeutic sites on the torso where the *qi* of the *zangfu* gathers.

Clinical Methodology: Point Selection and Safety

Point Selection Methods

1. **Local and Adjacent:** Selecting points at or near the site of disease (e.g., *Jingming* BL-1 for eye disorders).
2. **Distal Selection:** The most frequent method, using points on the limbs to treat the head, chest, or abdomen.
3. **Front-Back/Above-Below:** Combining points on opposite sides of the body or using lower body points to "draw down" excess from the head.
4. **Contralateral (Cross-needling):** Needling the healthy side to treat the affected side, particularly in acute sprains or chronic hemiplegia.

The Cun Measurement System

A proportional measurement system allows for accurate point location regardless of a patient's size.

- **Width of the thumb interphalangeal joint:** 1 Cun.
- **Width of four fingers held together:** 3 Cun.
- **Distance between the umbilicus and pubic symphysis:** 5 Cun.

Critical Safety Precautions

- **Pneumothorax Prevention:** Deep perpendicular or oblique needling is strictly forbidden over the thoracic cavity (chest and back). Symptoms of pneumothorax include chest pain, cough, and shortness of breath.

- **Organ Protection:** Specific care must be taken near the liver, spleen, kidneys, and heart, especially in emaciated patients.
- **Major Vessels:** Needling near arteries (like the radial artery) requires caution. If bleeding occurs, pressure must be applied (1 minute for veins, 3 minutes for arteries).

The Lung Channel of Hand Taiyin

The Lung channel is the first in the circuit of *qi*. It governs respiration, controls disseminating and descending *qi*, and regulates water passages.

Key Points of the Lung Channel

- **Zhongfu LU-1 (Front-Mu):** Clears excess from the Lung *zang*, treats cough, asthma, and fullness in the chest.
- **Chize LU-5 (He-Sea):** Clears all forms of heat from the Lung; treats coughing blood, vomiting, and elbow pain.
- **Kongzui LU-6 (Xi-Cleft):** Essential for acute asthma and coughing blood.
- **Lieque LU-7 (Luo-Connecting/Confluent):** The principal point for releasing the exterior and expelling wind. It is a "Command Point" for the head and nape and regulates the Conception vessel.
- **Taiyuan LU-9 (Yuan-Source/Hui-Meeting):** The primary point for tonifying Lung *qi* and *yin*; also the meeting point of the pulse and vessels.
- **Shaoshang LU-11 (Jing-Well):** Frequently pricked and bled for acute, severe sore throat and mumps.

Clinical Indications Summary

The Lung channel points primarily treat:

1. **Respiratory disorders:** Cough, wheezing, dyspnoea.
2. **Exterior syndromes:** Chills, fever, and nasal congestion from wind invasion.
3. **Water metabolism:** Oedema and obstructed urination.
4. **Channel pain:** Pain in the shoulder, arm, and thumb.